

**Workshop**

All you can do with Swift Playgrounds, Apple's app for the iPad to get children started with programming.

**63****Feature**

Applications and websites used everyday and the slew of hidden features they carry.

**66**

# REVAMPING YOUR ANDROID PHONE'S UI

Rooted or non-rooted, we transform your  
Android's interface.



Abhijit Dey  
[abhijit@digit.in](mailto:abhijit@digit.in)

The theme inside an Android phone isn't the same across every OEM, since they implement their own skin with several modifications over the stock theme. While these modifications enhance the vanilla experience of Android (offered by few OEMs and preferred by many), they aren't really customisation friendly. The maximum you would be able to do is change your wallpaper, replace the icons and install a third-party launcher on non-rooted phones. But serious transformation comes only with rooted phones pushing the possibilities immensely, where you'll also be able to change the layout of system apps, system icon colours and positions, and much more.

It's not only the visual feel but you can have an enhanced and more productive interface, with subtle additions such as a launcher that automatically categorises your favourite

or most used apps. As mentioned earlier, rooted phones are more open to customisation since modification is granted to the system files. This makes it possible to update your menu icons, boot animation, overall colour scheme, etc. We'll be covering both the fronts, and since the visual styling of your personal phone is highly subjective, we'll only be suggesting the possible changes you can make, starting off with non-rooted phones.

## Custom launchers

Usually the default launchers from OEMs are basic and offer minimum options for extra functionality. For instance, there's Samsung's TouchWiz, HTC's Sense, ASUS' ZenUI, Google's Google Now Launcher etc. that offer limited functionality, few of them including theme support. If you want to break off from these restrictions, then there are a few third-party launchers that enable a huge potential for customisation. There are numerous options available for third-party

launchers on the Play Store, and it wouldn't be practical to cover all of them. The following are a few of the lot which cover different use-case scenarios since the core functionalities are the same in all of them.

## Nova Prime

Nova is the best third-party launcher we've used so far. The basic version has an exhaustive list of features and customisations, where the premium version, Nova Prime includes even more of them. You can change the behaviour of your homescreen, app drawer, dock and folders. The Desktop menu lets you change the grid of your homescreen for apps and widgets, resize the app icons and play around with the font (if supported), and increase or decrease the transition animations for scrolling. App and widget drawers lets you tweak up all the transitions and layout of the app drawer right from the background to the grid. It also includes gesture support and an add-on to display a notification count badge for specific apps.